

Sending 15 substantial compositions as application for an Austrian State Stipendium for impecunious young artists in 1875, he was described as “Anton Dworak of Prague, 33 years old, music teacher, completely without means.” He won the prize three times, in 1874, 1876, and 1877. On the jury were the conductor Johann Herbeck, the critic Eduard Hanslick, and the composer Johannes Brahms; the latter was “visibly overcome” by Dvořák’s “mastery and talent.”

Much encouraged, Dvořák left his orchestral job, redoubled his efforts, and in 1875 finished three chamber works, a song cycle, his Fifth Symphony, and the Serenade for Strings. Brahms befriended him and introduced him to the publisher Fritz Simrock, who commissioned his first set of Slavonic Dances.